

Around the Post (ATP)

1. Lesson Recap

This lesson covers the around-the-post shot, usually called the ATP. This is the shot where a wide ball lets you swing it back into the court around the *outside* of the net post instead of over the net.

The ATP is completely legal. When the ball pulls you wide enough, you do not have to clear the net at all, and there is no height limit on the shot. You can hit it low, flat, and hard, and your opponents often cannot reach it.

The main idea is recognition and patience: let a wide ball travel, get beside it, and drive it back across the open court. It looks flashy, but it comes from a simple read.

2. Big Idea

If the ball pulls you wide of the sideline, let it keep traveling and take it *around* the post, not over the net.

Think: "wide ball, let it run, swing it back in." The wider and lower the ball gets, the easier and more aggressive the ATP becomes.

3. Key Cues

- "Wide ball, let it travel."
- "Don't reach early."
- "Move with the ball, not at it."
- "Get beside the ball."
- "Below the net is fine."
- "Swing back toward the open court."
- "Flat and firm, no need to lift."
- "Aim for the angle, not the line."
- "If it's not wide enough, just hit a normal shot."
- "Recover to the kitchen after."

4. Step-by-Step

1. Read the wide ball early. The ATP only exists when the ball is pulling you past the sideline, not in front of you.
2. Let the ball keep traveling outward. Do not reach out and grab it too soon. The farther wide it goes, the better your angle.
3. Move your feet so your body ends up beside the ball, level with it or slightly behind it, out past the post.
4. Let the ball drop low if it wants to. Below the height of the net is fine, because you are going around the post, not over it.
5. Set a stable base. Plant your outside foot so you are balanced, not lunging.
6. Make contact out to the side with a compact, firm swing. No big lift is needed since the net is not in your way.
7. Aim back into the open court at an angle. The whole diagonal of the court is your target.
8. Drive it firmly. A clean ATP is usually unreachable, so commit instead of dinking it softly.

9. Recover quickly back toward the kitchen line with your partner once the ball is gone.

5. Common Mistakes

- Reaching too early: Hitting the ball while it is still over the court turns an easy ATP into an awkward stretch volley. Let it travel wide first.
- Trying to clear the net: Players instinctively lift the ball up and over. On a true ATP you go around the post, so a low, flat path is correct.
- Forcing it when the ball isn't wide enough: If the ball is not pulling you past the sideline, the post is in your way. Just hit a normal shot instead.
- Lunging off balance: Swinging while falling sideways kills your control. Move your feet so you arrive beside the ball and stay balanced.
- Aiming straight up the line: A line shot is low percentage. Use the angle back across the open court for a safer, harder-to-reach target.
- Forgetting to recover: After the highlight shot, players freeze. Get back to the kitchen in case the ball comes back.

6. Self-Check

- Was the ball actually wide enough to go around the post?
- Did I let the ball travel instead of reaching for it early?
- Did I get my body beside the ball with a stable base?
- Did I keep the swing compact and firm?
- Did I aim back into the open court at an angle?
- Was I balanced at contact, or was I lunging?
- Did the ball stay low and flat instead of looping up?
- Did I recover toward the kitchen after the shot?

7. Homework

Practice these before your next play session:

- Wide-feed recognition drill: Have a partner (or a ball machine) feed balls that pull you wide of the sideline. Catch 15 of them in your non-paddle hand instead of hitting. The goal is training your eyes to recognize a true ATP ball and to let it travel.
- Shadow footwork: Without a ball, shadow-swing 10 ATPs on each side. Practice stepping out beyond an imaginary post, planting your outside foot, and making a compact swing while balanced.
- Cone target ATP drill: Place a cone or towel in the opposite diagonal corner. Have a partner feed you wide balls and hit 20 ATPs total (10 from each side), aiming for the angled target rather than the sideline.
- Let-it-drop reps: From a wide feed, deliberately let the ball drop low, below net height, before you swing. Hit 15 of these so you get comfortable contacting a low ball around the post.
- Live-point awareness task: During recreational play, do not force the shot. Just notice every time a ball pulls you wide and quietly tell yourself "ATP chance." Building recognition matters more than landing one right away.

8. Game Application 🎮

Use the ATP when a sharp angled shot, often a cross-court dink or drive, pulls you clearly outside the sideline. That is the only time the shot is really available.

Do not go looking for the ATP. It is an opportunity shot, not a plan. If you try to manufacture it from a ball that is not wide enough, you will hit the post or spray the ball out. When in doubt, hit a normal reset or dink and stay in the point.

When the chance is real, be decisive. A committed, firm ATP into the open court is usually a clean winner because your opponents are stuck behind the net. After you hit it, recover with your partner so you are not caught out of position if it somehow comes back.

9. Visualization 👁

Picture a hard cross-court ball angling toward your sideline. Instead of panicking, you stay calm and let it keep traveling wide. Your feet move with it, and you arrive beside the ball, balanced and ready, out past the net post.

The ball has dropped low, but that is fine. You take a short, firm swing and send it flat back across the court at an angle. You see it skip past your opponents, who never had a chance to reach it. You feel balanced, you hear the clean contact, and you calmly step back toward the kitchen for the next ball.

10. Quick Reminders 🏆

- Watch for wide balls that pull you past the sideline.
- Let the ball travel; don't reach early.
- Get beside the ball and stay balanced.
- Low and flat is fine; you're going around, not over.
- Aim back into the open court at an angle.
- If it isn't wide enough, just hit a normal shot.
- Recover to the kitchen after.

11. Resources

Use these resources for optional review away from the court. The lesson notes above are your main practice plan.

Articles

- [The Pickleball Around-the-Post \(ATP\) Shot](#)

Source: PlayPickleball

A clear explanation of what the ATP is, when it is legal, and the official rule that allows the ball to travel around the outside of the post without clearing the net.

- [How to Hit an ATP in Pickleball: Around-the-Post Guide](#)

Source: The Dink

A practical step-by-step breakdown of footwork, contact point, and how to recognize when the shot is actually available.

- [The Pickleball Around-the-Post Shot Explained: Tips for Beginners](#)

Source: Selkirk TV

A beginner-friendly explainer from pickleball official Maddie Toren covering what is allowed on an ATP and the most common misunderstandings about the shot.

YouTube Videos

- [How To Hit An Around The Post \(ATP\) Shot](#)

Channel: PrimeTime Pickleball

A popular, well-explained tutorial on how to set up and execute the ATP, including how to read the wide ball that makes it possible.

- [How to Hit the ATP | Pickleball](#)

Channel: Nicholas Wade

A quick, easy tutorial that simplifies the footwork and contact point, useful for getting comfortable with the basic motion.

- [How to Hit an ATP \(Around the Post\) Shot](#)

Channel: LevelUp Pickleball

A short, focused clip from a camp head pro covering how and, importantly, *when* to go for the ATP.

Rules and Strategy References

- [USA Pickleball Official Rulebook \(Rule 11.M — Around the Post\)](#)

Source: USA Pickleball

The official rules confirm a player may return the ball around the outside of the net post, and that the ball does not need to travel back over the net or stay above net height. This is why the ATP is a fully legal shot.